CINEMA

# A Writer's World

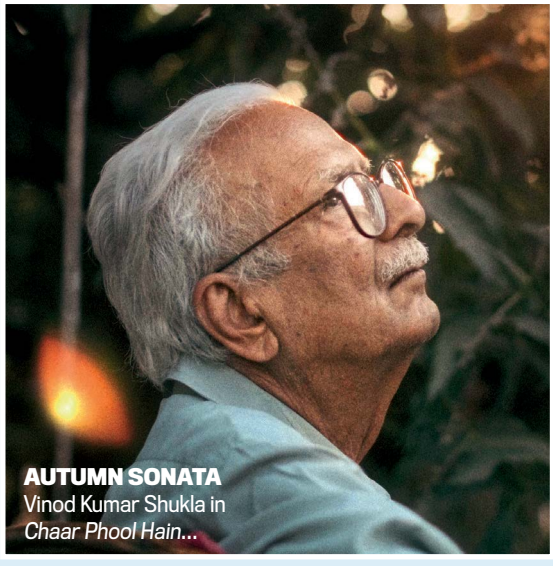
**ACHAL MISHRA'S *CHAAR PHOOL HAIN AUR DUNIYA HAI* IS AN INTIMATE PORTRAIT OF THE NOTED HINDI WRITER VINOD KUMAR SHUKLA**

Back in 2022, when actor Manav Kaul asked Achal Mishra to tag along for his meeting with renowned author Vinod Kumar Shukla at his home in Raipur, he knew a film could come out of it. "I went over-prepared," Mishra tells INDIA TODAY. The filmmaker carried two cameras, tripods and an entire lot of sound-recording equipment. But fate had other plans. For a significant portion of the day, he found himself unable to shoot anything as he turned into a starstruck fan whenever Shukla, the 2024 Jnanpith award winner and now 88, started speaking. "I ended up just listening," he says. Mishra couldn't believe his luck—that he was in the same room as one of Hindi's greatest living writers and, incidentally, also the only Indian recipient of the PEN/ Nabokov Award for International Literature.

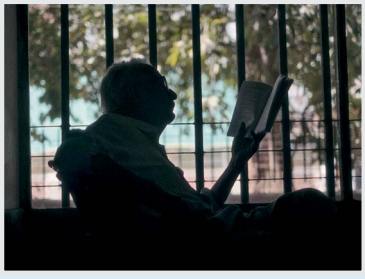
As it turned out, a film did emerge from the two afternoons that Mishra and Kaul spent with the writer. In the gentle *Chaar Phool Hain Aur Duniya Hai*, Mishra, who also shot, edited, and produced the film, paints an intimate portrait of Shukla as an artist whose art consumes and nourishes him. The 54-minute documentary is built largely around conversations and anecdotes—right from Shukla's middle-aged son offering perspective on Shukla's fertile imagination to Kaul prodding the 88-year-old writer about the length and breadth of his creative imagination. Mishra, who previously found acclaim helming *Gamak Ghar* (2019) and *Dhuin* (2022), films that wrestled with the spaces and faces of small-town India, attempts something similar in his first documentary, drawing a connection between Shukla's home and his artistry.

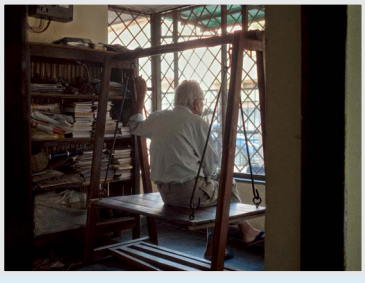
In the two years that it took to edit the film, Mishra was certain about one thing: he didn't want it to end up as a career highlight reel of the writer. "The idea was a viewer could find something new in the film, even if you had followed Shukla's work closely or knew nothing about him." The filmmaker's decision to release *Chaar Phool Hain...* on MUBI—after premiering the film at the Dharamshala International Film Festival last year—stemmed from a similar desire for accessibility. "I wanted this film to reach as many people as possible." Still, aware of the limitations presented by an online streaming platform, Mishra has figured a foolproof way to ensure anyone can watch the film: make it available on YouTube at some point. ■

**– Poulomi Das**



**AUTUMN SONATA**
Vinod Kumar Shukla in *Chaar Phool Hain...*







***AN AWESTRUCK MISHRA SAYS FOR LONG PERIODS OF THEIR MEETING, HE COULD NOT SHOOT. "I ENDED UP JUST LISTENING"***